

ON TECHNIQUE

Master of orchestration

Ravel's orchestral works are admired for his skill in handling instrumental colors, and his extraordinary aural imagination. He made a point of studying the characteristics of all the orchestral instruments to make the most of the palette of different instrumental timbres for expressive effect, and to give clarity to harmonies and rhythms. Surprisingly, only a handful of these works were first conceived for orchestra: most were written as piano pieces that he later orchestrated, and almost all his music was composed at the piano.

Maurice Ravel was a French citizen but his father, an engineer and inventor, was Swiss, and his mother was Spanish-Basque. He was born in 1875 in Ciboure, near Biarritz, in the Basque region of France, but the family moved to Paris while Maurice was still a baby.

He and his younger brother, Edouard, were initially educated at home by their father. He gave them a solid grounding in technology and science, but also conveyed his love of the arts and music. Edouard shared his father's interest in engineering, while Maurice was drawn to his mother's love of Basque and Spanish folk culture, which was later reflected in many of his compositions.